



Siddharth D. Shanghvi

Ignore the **POWER BROKER**. It's a call to arms for the middle classes, time to wrest politics from the politician's hands.

In India, politicians have come down with politics as if it's a sexually transmitted disease; an affliction, a bane. Under the guise of governance, genocide, rape, torture have become institutionalised in India, all instruments in our War against Terror. Image associations with politicians scare me. Say Narendra Modi and I see flames. Say Raj Thackeray and I see broken glasses. Say Lalu Prasad and I see cowsheds of cash. While all countries have corruption in their system, only India has a system within the corruption; our system is officially a sleaze ecology. For when our politicians are not whorishly auctioning their votes on nuke deals, they're brokering development contracts with builders' lobbies.

To claim, my engagement with politics arose from my interest in considering large, dramatic ideas on justice, and public policy not only sounds lofty but also insincere. I came to politics—and political ideology—to understand what I own: in real terms, in cultural equity, in philosophical cavalry. To consider what is mine allows me to recognise what is not mine, and this distinction allows us all to live fairly in unfair times. The phrase “a political writer” has always carried such a whiff of self-importance that I always shied from its weight: not because I'm vain enough to think myself as modest, but because there are more dignified ways to be self-important. However, once I started to think of myself as a writer who happens to be political, a lowering of the semantic volume encouraged me to think powerfully and purposefully about the idea of what it means to be a citizen and to be politically engaged. In the process, I discovered my definition of being political is neither strident nor pacifist; it is not directly concerned with state bodies although it has to deal with them; it is not only personal but it is also ineluctably fused with my personhood. Perhaps, Aristotle

was right when he wrote that ethical life it is impossible to do politics”. I am more interested in existence than in governance: so came my means to an end.

Because I live in a big city—a lion shack up in Bombay—I had to break down enormous, anonymous gates and identify small, specific protect, and preserve within then gular and ineffably significant. I Juhu, the north Bombay suburb born and where I live. Luckily, sūtuency has an energetic, deterrent of political engagement. Advan Management models were established on here. MPs and activists like Sh are from Juhu, as was her Comr the poet Kaifi Azmi, who lived in Comprising an educated urban r Juhu is responsible for the electi first independent councillor, Adol well as being the first residen Bombay to go green (plastic recently been banned in Juhu). Ci cleaned up Juhu Beach, turning along the beach into ecological gardens. Juhu, from all accounts to get its hands muddy.

Civic engagement with local Sherry Singh assured me, is reas orous in Juhu. Singh, 41, a wife a two, a hotelier and volun Brihanmumbai Municipal Corpo school, is secretary of Juhu Scher Association. Feisty and industri Juhu home was flooded in the 2 deluge. “It was surreal,” she sai room was suddenly a swimming cars floated off into the tide.” Inc apathy in preventing further floor she kept tabs on monsoon mai Juhu. Singh discovered that acc

Rs 400 cr
WAS THE AMOUNT THAT
PRIME MINISTER
GAVE THE BMC TO
RECTIFY FLOODING
IN JUHU. BUT NOTHING
WAS DONE UNTIL
AN RTI.